

Concord: The Rules of Subject–Verb Agreement

Every rule you need for Section D, with clear examples

Study guide for the University of Ibadan Postgraduate Test of English (EPT)

Concord means agreement: a verb must agree with its subject in number (singular or plural) and person. Most concord mistakes happen when something gets in the way of spotting the true subject. The rules below show you how to find it.

EXAM TIP

A present-tense verb ending in **-s** is **singular** (*she goes*), the opposite of nouns, where **-s** usually means plural (*the girls*).

1 Singular subject, singular verb; plural subject, plural verb

✓ The car stays in the garage. / The cars stay in the garage.

2 Ignore words between the subject and the verb

Phrases beginning with *of*, *with*, *in*, *on* and so on do not change the subject. Mentally cross them out.

✓ One ~~of the eggs~~ is broken.

✓ The weather ~~on the coast~~ looks good.

3 Accompaniment: as well as, together with, along with, including, in addition to, alongside

These add information but do not join subjects, so the verb follows the **first** noun.

✓ The director, as well as her assistants, is travelling.

✓ The pupils, together with their teacher, are here.

4 Parenthesis: a phrase between commas does not count

✓ The manager, not his workers, is responsible.

5 Subjects joined by *and* are plural

✓ Bola and Ade are leaving.

Exception, one person or thing: if both nouns name the same person or form a single unit, the verb is singular. Notice the single article.

✓ Our principal and mathematics teacher knows me. (*one person*)

✓ The principal and the mathematics teacher know me. (*two people*)

Dishes and fixed pairs treated as one item also take a singular verb: *Bread and butter is my breakfast.*

6 Every and each with *and*: singular

✓ Every man and woman was given a form.

✓ Each boy and girl has a seat.

7 The rule of proximity: *or*, *either ... or*, *neither ... nor*, *not only ... but also*

The verb agrees with the subject **nearer** to it.

✓ Either the cups or the **glasses** are dirty.

✓ Neither the players nor the **coach** was ready.

✓ His teachers, his parents or I am to blame.

EXAM TIP

If one subject is singular and one plural, put the plural one last; the sentence then sounds natural with a plural verb.

8 Indefinite pronouns that are always singular

each, either, neither, one, everyone, everybody, everything, someone, somebody, something, anyone, anybody, anything, no one, nobody, nothing

✓ Everybody was asked to remain quiet.

✓ Neither of the answers is correct.

When a pronoun refers back to these words, formal English traditionally uses *his or her*.

✓ Everyone must bring his or her passport.

NOTE

Everyday English increasingly uses *their* here. In a formal exam, *his or her* is the safer choice.

9 Words that can go either way: some, any, all, most, none, half, part

Look at the noun that follows. Uncountable or singular means a singular verb; plural means a plural verb.

✓ Most of the water has evaporated. / Most of the seats were taken.

✓ All of the milk is gone. / All of the children are here.

All meaning "everything" is singular, and meaning "everybody" is plural: *All is well.* *All are seated.* Note also *All but John are on the bus.*

10 Each of / one of: plural noun, singular verb

✓ Each of the candidates stands a good chance.

✓ One of my friends believes in luck.

11 Relative clauses after "one of ... who/that"

The relative pronoun refers to the plural noun, so the verb inside the clause is plural, while the main verb agrees with *one*.

✓ One of the farmers who plant cassava has withdrawn.

12 Many a: singular noun, singular verb

✓ Many a candidate has made that mistake.

It means "many candidates", but grammatically it is singular.

13 A number of versus the number of

✓ A number of students have arrived. (= many; plural)

✓ The number of students has risen. (the figure itself; singular)

14 More than one and more than two

✓ More than one tree has fallen.

✓ More than two trees have fallen.

The noun after *more than* decides: *one tree* is singular even though the meaning is "at least two".

15 Collective nouns: unit or individuals?

Words such as *committee, team, jury, family, class, audience, government, club* take a **singular** verb when the group acts as one unit, and a **plural** verb when you are thinking of the members acting individually.

✓ The committee has approved the budget. (*one decision*)

✓ The jury were arguing among themselves. (*individuals*)

A clue: if the sentence uses *their* for the group, the members are being treated as individuals.

NOTE

Some notes circulating among applicants say collective nouns always take a plural verb when the group "performs an action". That is not the rule. It depends on unit versus individuals, as above.

16 Nouns that are always plural

police, people, cattle, clergy, vermin, and paired items such as *trousers, scissors, spectacles, pliers*; also *goods, earnings, riches, surroundings, remains, outskirts, savings, thanks, arrears*.

✓ The police are investigating. (But: That policeman is investigating.)

✓ The scissors are sharp. / A pair of scissors is on the table.

With *a pair of*, the verb agrees with *pair* (singular).

17 Nouns that look plural but are singular

Subjects of study (*mathematics, physics, economics, statistics*), diseases (*measles, mumps*), games (*draughts, billiards*) and *news*.

✓ Mathematics is my favourite subject.

✓ The news was encouraging.

Series and *means* are singular when you mean one: *This series of lectures is useful.*

18 Uncountable nouns: never add -s

information, advice, equipment, furniture, luggage, evidence, knowledge, machinery, research are uncountable. They take a singular verb and no plural -s.

✓ The information was accurate.

✗ The informations were accurate.

To count them, use a unit: *a piece of advice, two items of equipment*.

19 Amounts of time, money, distance and weight

Treated as one quantity, they take a singular verb.

- ✓ Five thousand naira is too much for that book.
- ✓ Ten years is a long time.
- ✓ Twenty percent of my salary goes to rent.

20 Titles and names of organisations

The name of one book, film, company or country is singular even if it looks plural.

- ✓ *Things Fall Apart* is a classic.
- ✓ The United States is a large country.

21 The + adjective (the poor, the rich, the young)

These mean "poor people", "rich people" and so on, and are plural.

- ✓ The poor need support. / The young are impatient.

22 There and here are never the subject

Find the real subject after the verb.

- ✓ There are many reasons. / Here is the report.
- ✓ There is a pen and two books on the desk. (*many writers agree with the first item*)

23 The mandative subjunctive

After verbs and nouns of demand, suggestion or recommendation (*suggest, recommend, insist, demand, request, it is essential that*), formal English uses the **base form** of the verb for every subject: no -s, and *be* instead of *is/are*.

- ✓ The board recommended that the manager resign.
- ✓ It is essential that every candidate be punctual.

NOTE

Some notes describe this as using a "plural verb". It is really the base form: *that he go*, not *that he goes*.

24 Don't and doesn't

Use *doesn't* with *he, she, it* and singular nouns; *don't* with *I, you, we, they* and plural nouns.

- ✓ She doesn't agree. / They don't agree.

A quick method for any concord item

1. Find the verb gap.
2. Cross out phrases between subject and verb (*of...*, *with...*, *as well as...*, anything between commas).
3. Ask what the true subject is. Is it one thing, several things, or a special noun (collective, uncountable, always-plural, amount)?
4. If the subjects are joined by *or/nor*, use the nearer one.
5. Read the sentence back with your choice. It should sound balanced in formal English.

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